signatory of the 1951 UN convention relating to the Status of Refugees or the 1967 Protocol, nor having any specific legal framework and national refugee status determination system, India had little recourse to accommodate Afghan refugees. To make things worse, a monthly subsistence allowance for refugees was stopped by the government as early as 1992, earning complaints from the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR).[25]

Effectively, all the three drivers of India's Afghanistan policy—New Delhi's desire to strike a balance between Afghanistan and Pakistan, international political environment, and domestic Afghan politics—favoured anti-Taliban partisanship in March 2001. Given the global outcry over the destruction of the Buddha and the IC-814 hijacking episode, India's diplomatic and military measures against the Taliban were to be expected. Domestic political factors supplemented these dynamics. Differences between a Hindu nationalist government and a militant Islamist regime coupled with deteriorating relations between India and Pakistan ensured the domination of partisans. However, apart from the IC-814 episode, a lot more had happened between 1996 and 2001 that helped partisans remain dominant within India's establishment. The demolition of the Buddhas only vindicated a growing partisan trend and fed into an aggressive political discourse against Islamist politics that had already begun to crystalise globally and later became the 'war on terror', as the twentieth century came to an end.

Six plus two

Disconnected geographically and limited in capacity, India adopted an internationalist strategy towards Afghanistan. Unilaterally, as most parliamentarians thought, it did little. Whenever the government was questioned in the parliament about its Afghanistan policy, a slew of UN resolutions that India supported (or co-sponsored) were offered. India's participation in the Group of 21 countries that was created in November 1996, as well as cooperation with Russia, Iran, and the US was also displayed as a mechanism to secure national interests in Afghanistan.[26] Such an internationalist approach was combined with vague assurances of tightened border controls, gearing up the